and Library (NMML) and the National Archives of India (NAI), but I fortunately made it in. Mining the back volumes of *Swadesamitran* on microfilm in NMML threw open a new world, as did the other documentary riches in these fabulous repositories. Three years later, as a postgraduate student, when I visited the library again, the passage was made much smoother by the support of Haridev Sharma, its deputy director. In 1990, I joined the Centre for Historical Studies at Jawaharlal Nehru University as a doctoral student, and Teen Murti Bhavan became my regular haunt.

In late 1996, with a grant provided by the Charles Wallace India Trust, I explored many libraries in Britain. The British Library is the Mecca for historians. Its riches need no restating. Following an inspired hunch, I had written to the Lloyd's Register of Shipping in 1987. The world's oldest ship classification society was not only prompt in providing information but also directed me to its records held on microfilm at the Guildhall Library, City of London. Tracing the day-to-day movement of the Swadeshi steamers was truly exhilarating. The National Maritime Museum opened another new world, even though I did not find much material directly relevant to my work. The BISN records held there have little to say on its business in Tuticorin.

The Indo–French Exchange Programme fellowships (which I undertook in 1996 and 1998) enabled access to the archives of the ship classification society, Bureau Veritas, Paris. Its records corroborated the information collected by the Lloyd's Register of Shipping. At the Bibliothèque nationale de France, I accessed the only surviving issues of Bharati's daily, *Vijaya*. Appasamy Murugaiyan provided indispensable help in this regard.

As a Charles Wallace visiting fellow (2006) at the Centre of South Asian Studies, University of Cambridge, I exploited its resources fully. Special mention needs to be made of the help provided by Kevin Greenbank, Rachel Rowe and Barbara Roe.

Though I have researched in the above repositories on numerous occasions subsequently, these first encounters remain close to my heart like first love.